

WHAT IS A PHRASE?

A phrase is a group of words whose meaning is incomplete, although the group of words is part of a sentence.

A phrase could also be defined as a group of words without a finite verb.

Phrases are usually named or identified through the head word. The head word could be a noun, verb, adverb, adjective or preposition.

TYPES OF PHRASES

Since phrases are usually named or identified through the head word, however, there are basically five types of English phrases namely:

Noun Phrase: A noun phrase is a phrase that has a noun or pronoun as its head word. It could be pre-modified by an article, a possessive of demonstrative pronoun or an adjective. The words underlined are noun phrases:

- The girl and her friends ate many oranges.
- This apple is very sour.
- Our teachers are hardworking.

Verb Phrase: a verb phrase is a word group that indicates the predicate of a sentence. It includes a main verb and its auxiliaries (helping verbs). The words underlined are verb phrases:

- The girl and her friends ate many oranges.
- This apple is very sour.
- Our teachers are going on strike.

Adverb Phrase: An adverb phrase is a group of words that serves the purpose of an adverb; also known as adverbial phrase. An adverb is a word used to modify a verb, an adjective or another adverb. The adverb is the head of the phrase and can appear alone or it can be modified by other words. The words underlined are adverb phrases:

- We usually go on holiday in August.
- Time goes very quickly.
- He behaved rudely.

Adjective Phrase: An adjective phrase is a group of words that describe a noun or pronoun in a sentence. The adjective phrase can be placed before, or after, the noun or pronoun in the sentence. The words underlined are adjective phrases:

- The movie was not too terribly long.
- The final exams were unbelievably difficult.
- Faster than a speeding bullet, Superman was finished in no time.

Prepositional Phrase: A prepositional phrase is a phrase that starts with a preposition and ends with noun (or a pronoun). The words underlined are prepositional phrases:

- We will be back in a few days.
- We've got a new television with a thirty one inch screen.
- I saw a wonderful painting by James.

I feel sorry for you.